

Prisoners of War

The number of Americans held prisoner or categorized as missing was relatively small, but the fate of American prisoners of war in North Vietnam became a burning political issue during the war, throughout the peace negotiations, and after the conflict was over.

◀◀ BEFORE

Some Americans became prisoners of war in Vietnam in the early 1960s well before the major deployment of US forces later in the decade and remained in captivity for many years.

THE FIRST PRISONER

Lieutenant Everett Alvarez was shot down over North Vietnam on August 5, 1964, in Operation Pierce Arrow, the initial bombing raid in the immediate aftermath of the [Tonkin Gulf Incident](#). He became the first pilot to be **held prisoner** in North Vietnam and remained in captivity for eight and a half years.

LONGEST CAPTIVITY

The longest-held American prisoner was US Army Special Forces Captain Floyd James Thompson who was **captured** in South Vietnam on March 26, 1964, after only three months in the country. He was not released for almost nine years.

In February and March 1973, 691 Americans (mostly military but also a few civilians) were released from prisons in North Vietnam. Four American prisoners held in China also were freed. Many of these surviving prisoners had suffered extreme hardships in captivity. Estimates are that 55 to 75 POWs died. About 2,300 other Americans were deemed to be missing in action (MIA). Most of them died in fiery crashes or at the hands of guerrillas in remote areas, and few remains were ever found. Most of these men were later reclassified as KIA/BNR (Killed in Action/Body Not Recovered).

Hanoi Hilton

American captives were held in 11 different prisons, but the majority of the approximately 700 POWs were crowded into the cell blocks of Hoa Lo Prison in Hanoi. Known to Americans as the Hanoi Hilton, it was once a French jail holding Viet Minh suspects. A large fortress covering a city block, it had 20-foot (6 m) high walls that were topped with electrified barbed wire. Sanitation, food, and health care were poor.

Many prisoners were isolated and tortured in special interrogation rooms in attempts to secure confessions for propaganda use. Mistreatment included beatings, shackling, being held in darkness for extended periods, and being denied washing facilities. Despite often inhumane treatment, prisoners devised ingenious methods of surreptitious communication and found ways to keep up morale. The Hanoi Hilton held some prisoners who were destined for later prominence, including Medal of Honor winner and later admiral James B. Stockdale and future senator and presidential candidate John McCain.

Conditions in the prison began to improve after 1969. The reasons are unclear but may have related to North Vietnam's perceptions of US military de-escalation and the possibilities for negotiation raised by the POW issue.